

Build your own small business website.

Nine steps, in plain language, from picking a name to going live. The same process we follow when we build a site for a client.

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Most guides about building a website are written to sell you something by paragraph four. This one is not.

Work through these nine steps and you will have a real website that works on a phone, shows up when someone searches your name, and gives customers a way to reach you. It takes most people a weekend.

If you get to the end and decide you would rather hand it off, we do that too, and the last page tells you exactly what that costs.

STEP 01

Decide what the site has to do

Before you pick a color or a font, answer one question: **what do you want a visitor to do?** Almost every small business site has a single job, and the whole page should push toward it.

- **Call or text you.** Trades, towing, legal, anything urgent.
- **Book an appointment.** Salons, studios, clinics, trainers.
- **Order or buy.** Food, retail, products.
- **Find your hours and location.** Walk in businesses like a laundromat or a cafe.
- **Get a quote.** Contractors, event services, consultants.

Pick one. The others can still live on the page, but the main one gets the big button at the top. A site that asks people to do five things gets them to do none, the same way a menu with ninety items makes you order the chicken.

STEP 02

Pick a name and buy the domain

Your domain is your address on the internet, like `yourbusiness.com`. You rent it yearly, usually for ten to twenty dollars, from a registrar such as Namecheap, Porkbun, or Cloudflare.

Choosing the name

- Use your business name if it is available. Short beats clever.
- If it is taken, add your city or your trade. That also helps you locally.
- Take `.com` first. If it is gone, `.co` and `.net` are fine.
- Say it out loud. If you have to spell it over the phone, pick another one.
- No hyphens and no numbers. People forget them every time.

Buying it

1. Search the name at your registrar.
2. Decline the extras at checkout, except privacy protection, which is usually free and keeps your home address out of public records.
3. Turn on auto renew. A lapsed domain is the most common way a small business loses its website.
4. Save the login somewhere you will find it in two years.

WHERE PEOPLE GET STUCK

Buying the domain inside a website builder instead of at a registrar. It feels easier, and it is, until you want to move. Buy it separately and keep it in your own name. The domain is the one piece of this that is genuinely yours.

STEP 03

Choose where the site will live

Your domain is the address. Hosting is the lot the building sits on. You have three realistic paths.

All in one builders

Squarespace, Wix, and similar tools give you hosting, templates, and a drag and drop editor for a monthly fee. Easiest path if you have never done this. The cost is ongoing, and the site is hard to move later.

WordPress

More power, more moving parts, and more maintenance. Worth it if you plan to publish a lot of content or need a specific plugin. Not worth it for a five section page.

A plain HTML page on free hosting

If you are comfortable with a little code, a single HTML file on Cloudflare Pages or Netlify is free, loads faster than anything else, and never needs updating. This is what we use for the sites we build.

For most owners reading this, the honest answer is a builder. Pick one, take the free trial, and do not spend two weeks comparing them. The builder matters far less than the words on the page.

STEP 04

The five sections every page needs

You do not need ten pages. One good page, in this order, beats a maze every time.

1. **Hero.** Your business name, what you do, the city you serve, and the main button. A visitor should know in four seconds whether they are in the right place.
2. **Services.** Three to five things you do, each with one short sentence. Prices if you are comfortable showing them, and a range is fine.
3. **About.** Two or three sentences on who you are and why you are worth trusting.
4. **Proof.** Reviews, photos of finished work, licenses, awards, or logos of places you have worked with.
5. **Contact.** Phone, email, address if people come to you, hours, a map, and a form. Repeat the main button here.

Put your phone number in the header too, and make it tappable on a phone. More than half your visitors are on a phone, standing somewhere, deciding whether to call you.

STEP 05

Write the words

This is the part people avoid for three weeks. Do not write like a brochure. Write the way you would explain your business to a neighbor. Fill in these blanks and you have a first draft.

- **Hero:** "[Business name] is a [what you are] in [city]. We help [who] with [what]." Then the button: "Call now," "Book a time," "Get a quote."
- **Service line:** "[Service name]. [One sentence about what the customer gets, not what you do.]"
- **About:** "We have been [doing this] in [city] since [year]. [What makes you different.] [One sentence that sounds like a human being.]"
- **Contact:** "Call or text [number], or fill out the form and we will get back to you within [time]."

Two rules. Use the word "you" more than the word "we." And name your city in the first sentence, because that is what people actually search for.

STEP 06

Photos when you have none

Bad photos hurt a site more than no photos. You have three options, in order of preference.

1. **Take your own, in daylight.** Sun behind you, shoot in landscape, hold still, take twenty and keep three.
2. **Use free licensed stock.** Unsplash and Pexels allow commercial use. Avoid the obvious handshake and headset pictures.
3. **Use no photos at all.** A clean page built from strong type, color, and simple shapes looks intentional. An empty gray box does not.

Before you upload anything, shrink it. A photo straight off a phone is often five megabytes and will make your page crawl. Resize to about 1600 pixels wide and save as JPEG at around 80 percent quality. Squoosh.app does this free in your browser.

One more thing: never use a photo you found on Google. Those belong to someone, and the letters that follow are expensive.

STEP 07

Set up your Google Business Profile

For a local business, this free listing often sends more customers than the website itself. It is what shows up in the map results when someone searches your trade plus your city.

1. Go to google.com/business and claim or create your listing.
2. Verify it. Google will mail a postcard, call, or ask for a video, depending on the category.
3. Fill in every field: hours, service area, phone, website, categories, and a short description.
4. Add at least five photos. Listings with photos get far more clicks.
5. Ask your five best customers for a review, and reply to every review you get, including the unhappy ones.

Make sure your name, address, and phone number are written exactly the same way on the listing and on your website. Google compares them, and small mismatches like "Ave" versus "Avenue" quietly cost you rankings.

STEP 08

Connect the domain

This is the step where most weekend projects stall. Your domain lives at the registrar, your site lives at the host, and you have to introduce them. That introduction is called DNS, and you do it by adding two records.

1. In your host, add a custom domain and type in yours. It will show you the records it needs.
2. Log in to your registrar and open the DNS settings for your domain.
3. Add an **A record** for the root, usually shown as @, pointing to the IP address your host gave you.
4. Add a **CNAME record** for www, pointing to the address your host gave you.
5. Save, then wait. Changes usually take a few minutes and occasionally a few hours.
6. Check that HTTPS works, meaning the padlock shows in the browser.

WHERE PEOPLE GET STUCK

Two things go wrong here. First, editing DNS at the wrong place when your registrar and your host are different companies. Second, giving up during the wait and changing the records again, which restarts the clock. Make the change once, then go do something else for an hour.

STEP 09

The go live checklist

Run this list before you tell anyone the site is up.

- ☐ Open it on your phone. Read every line. Tap every button.
- ☐ Tap the phone number. It should start a call.
- ☐ Submit your own contact form and confirm the message arrives. Check spam.
- ☐ Click every link, including the footer.
- ☐ Read the page out loud to catch typos your eyes skip.
- ☐ Check the browser tab title. It should say your business name and city, not "Home."
- ☐ Confirm hours, address, and phone match your Google listing exactly.
- ☐ Add the link to your Google listing, Facebook, Instagram bio, and email signature.
- ☐ Set a reminder for eleven months from now to confirm the domain renewed.

That is the whole job. Nine steps, one weekend, and a site that does what it is supposed to do.

If you would rather not

Here is the honest version. Everything in this guide is doable, and plenty of owners do it. It also takes a weekend you may not have, and steps two and eight are where most people lose an evening.

That is the part we do. You fill out a form about your business, pick a style, and we build the page, connect the domain, and hand you a finished site.

We will build it for you

A single page, built from your answers, live within twenty four hours of your domain being connected. Starts at seventy five dollars, with revisions included.

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Either way, build the thing. A business without a website is invisible to the people already looking for it.